

The Gardener

I've always loved flowers, not just for their beauty, but also for how they live. Swaying in the wind, bright and carefree, basking in the sunlight as if the world wasn't full of storms. I watch them and imagine a life like theirs—calm and gentle, where each day is a new beginning, a slow unfolding of petals as time moves quietly. But they live knowing that one day, they will wither, and they accept that. They do not mourn the inevitable, nor do they hold onto the past. If only I could live as they do, free from the weight of what comes next. But I'm not a flower. I'm a gardener. I spend my days carefully selecting flowers from the garden of life, studying them, learning their needs. I choose the ones that seem on the edge of wilting, the ones with sharp thorns that keep others away. I convince myself I can make them thrive, that my care will change them. Each flower is unique, and I adapt to their demands like a tree bending under the weight of heavy fruit. I give them everything, my attention, my time, my heart. And still, no matter how hard I try, they all wither eventually. There was one flower, though, that stood apart from the others. It wasn't like the ones in my garden. It belonged to another gardener, someone who didn't understand it, who couldn't see the beauty I saw. I watched that flower struggle under his care—its petals drooping, its vibrant colors fading. I knew what it needed. I knew I could make it bloom again if only it were mine. I would watch it from a distance, admiring the way it still managed to stand tall despite the neglect. It wasn't mine, but I couldn't help but wish it were. I imagined how different it would be if I could tend to it, if I could provide the care and attention it deserved. I'd sneak into the other gardener's plot when he wasn't around, offering my touch in secret. With every stolen moment, the flower seemed to grow brighter, stronger. It responded to me in a way it never did to him.

We grew closer in those quiet moments, the flower and I. It was a connection that felt more real than anything I had experienced before. But it wasn't mine. I knew that, and so did the flower. It was bound to its own gardener, tied by roots that I couldn't sever. One day, the guilt became too much for it to bear. It confessed to the gardener about our secret moments together. The gardener, angry and protective, forbade the flower from receiving my care. Just like that, it was over. I stopped sneaking into his garden, and the flower stopped glowing under my touch. It stayed with him, and I was left to wonder if it was still wilting under his rough hands, or if it had

somehow found a way to survive without me. I miss it. Every day, I think about that flower and what we could have been. I wonder if it's still standing tall or if it has withered away completely. My own garden, which I had neglected while focusing on that one flower, seems duller now. The blooms I once cared for with such dedication have faded, and the soil feels dry beneath my feet. I try to move on, planting new flowers, giving them the care they need, but it's not the same. Every new flower I plant feels like an attempt to recreate what I lost. I pour my heart into them, hoping to find that same connection again, but none of them shine like that one did. None of them fill the void it left behind. I know I should be grateful for the flowers I have, but they all feel like replacements, shadows of what I once had.

Time moves on, and my garden continues to grow, but it never feels as vibrant as it did before. Each new bloom brings with it a brief sense of hope, a flicker of excitement. But I know, deep down, that they will all wither in time. I've seen it before, and I'll see it again. And yet, I can't stop myself from planting. From caring. From hoping. There's a part of me that believes that maybe, just maybe, I'll find another flower like the one I lost. A flower that won't just bloom under my care but will stay. A flower that won't belong to someone else, one that won't wilt despite my best efforts. But I know the truth. I know that I'm a gardener, not a flower. My role is to care for things that aren't mine to keep. To nurture what I can, even if it's just for a moment.

I'll always remember that one flower, though. The one that stood out from the rest. The one I wanted more than anything, but couldn't have. I'll always wonder what could have been if things had been different. If it had chosen me instead of staying in a garden where it wasn't cared for properly. I'll never know, and maybe that's for the best. Gardening is about acceptance. You learn to let go, to understand that not every flower is meant to stay in your garden. You give them what they need while they're with you, and when they leave, you hope that in some small way, you made a difference. But even knowing that doesn't make it easier to forget the ones that got away. So, I keep planting. Keep caring. Keep hoping. That's the life of a gardener. You pour everything you have into something, knowing full well that it might not last. You tell yourself that this time will be different, that this flower might bloom forever, even though you've seen it all before. And still, you can't help but plant again.